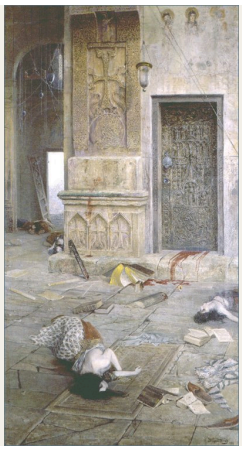
YEREVAN, ARMENIA

National Gallery of Armenia: Masterpieces

Church interiors, mountain views and painted legends offer different ways of giving a place historical weight.



In Sureniants's church interiors, buildings remain after violence has passed through them. Carved stone survives beside bodies or displaced objects. Elsewhere in this selection, a cathedral fills with a procession, an isolated ruin stands open to the sky, and mountains change with the weather.

Place is the connecting thread, but it does different work in each picture. Architecture can bear witness to damage; a landscape can establish distance; a patterned setting can absorb a figure into its colours. The portraits and still lifes offer a smaller scale of attention between these larger views. Together, the twenty-five works show how much can depend on the ground around a subject, rather than on the subject alone.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-armenia

The selection · 25

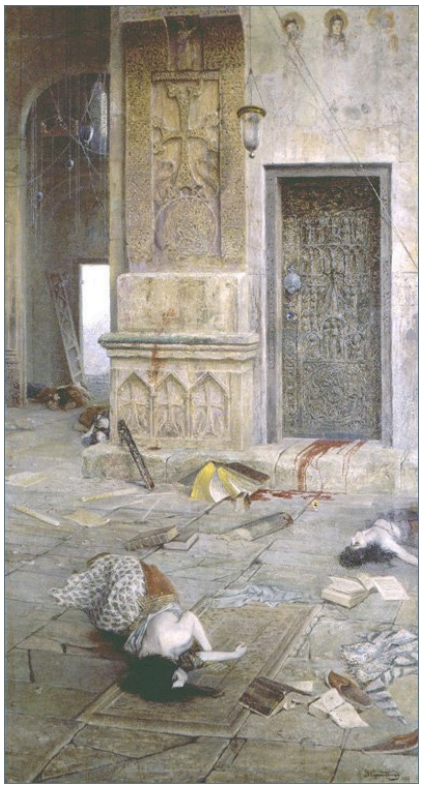
1. After the Massacre
   Vardges Sureniants · 1898
2. Desecrated Shrine
   Vardges Sureniants · 1895
3. The Return of Queen Zabel of Armenia
   Vardges Sureniants · 1909
4. Semiramis at the Body of Ara the Beautiful
   Vardges Sureniants · 1899
5. Portrait of Mkrtich Khrimian
   Vardges Sureniants · 1906
6. The Procession Leaving Etchmiadzin Cathedral
   Vardges Sureniants · 1895
7. Ani Cathedral
   Arshak Fetvadjian · 1905
8. Mount Ararat from Etchmiadzin
   Yeghishe Tadevosyan · 1895
9. Aragats
   Gevorg Bashinjaghian · 1917
10. Lake Sevan and Island in the Morning
    Gevorg Bashinjaghian · 1896
11. A Rainy Day at Sevan
    Gevorg Bashinjaghian · 1899
12. Birch Grove
    Gevorg Bashinjaghian · 1883
13. Mules Laden with Hay
    Martiros Saryan · 1910
14. Egyptian Masks
    Martiros Saryan · 1911
15. Café Pittoresque
    Georgy Yakulov · 1917
16. Komitas
    Yeghishe Tadevosyan · 1936
17. Talent and the Crowd
    Yeghishe Tadevosyan · 1909
18. The Courtyard of Sanahin Monastery
    Panos Terlemezyan · 1904
19. A Shepherd from Lori
    Panos Terlemezyan · 1905
20. Still Life with Vegetables
    Hmayak Hakobyan · 1901
21. Still Life: Plums
    Zakar Zakarian · 1900
22. Seascape
    Vartan Mahokian · 1905
23. The Siege of Kazan
    Nicholas Roerich · 1914
24. The Way of Giants
    Nicholas Roerich · 1914
25. Woman in a Blue Dress
    Victor Borisov-Musatov · 1903

01 / 25

After the Massacre

Vardges Sureniants

1898 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. After the Massacre. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The fighting is over. Bodies and scattered objects occupy the floor beneath carefully described carving, leaving a large, emptied volume above them. Sureniants makes aftermath the condition of looking: the architecture remains, but its use has been violently broken. The National Gallery's current exhibition account dates this painting to 1898, rather than the 1899 found in some older records.

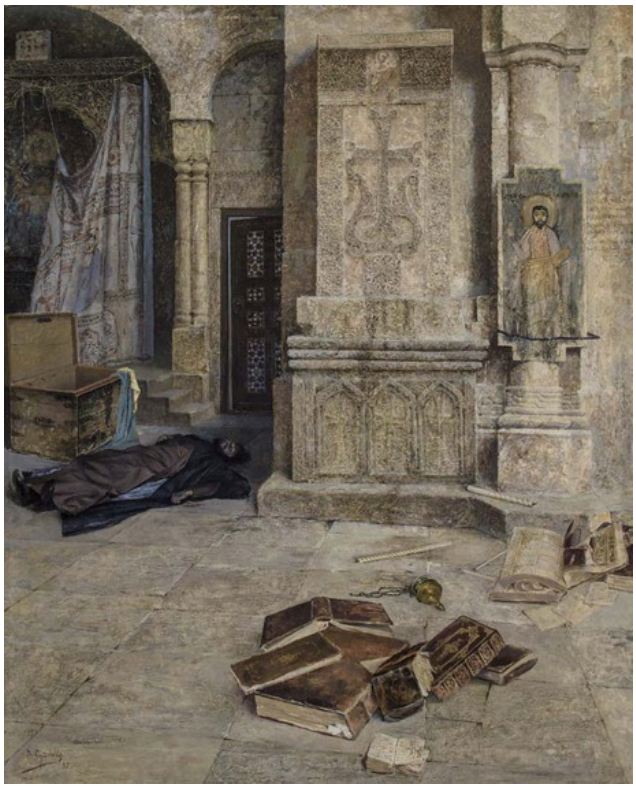
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 26944

02 / 25

Desecrated Shrine

Vardges Sureniants

1895 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. Desecrated Shrine. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Overturned objects disturb the order of a church whose piers and decorated walls remain standing. A shadowed doorway extends the space beyond what can be clearly examined. No central figure explains the violation. The relation between intact architecture and disordered contents makes the damage legible, requiring attention to the setting rather than to an isolated dramatic gesture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 69

03 / 25

The Return of Queen Zabel of Armenia

Vardges Sureniants

1909 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. Return of Queen Zabel of Armenia. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The queen's relatively clear patch of floor sets her apart from the attendants and armed figures crowding either side. Their gestures converge on her without dissolving that separation. Historical costume identifies a distant world, but the immediate encounter depends on spacing: one person remains exposed at the centre of several other people's attention and demands.

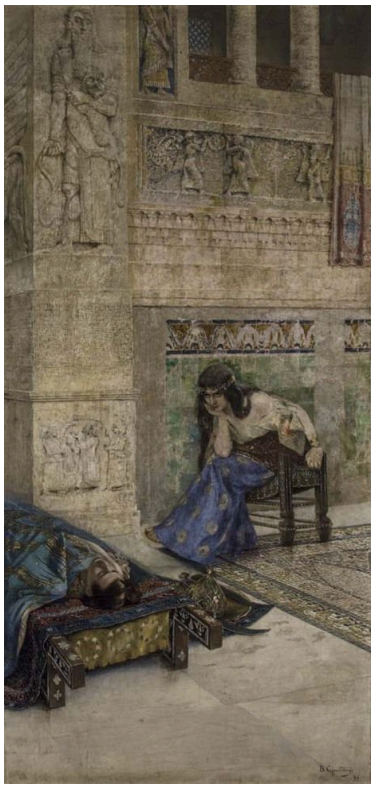
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 63

04 / 25

Semiramis at the Body of Ara the Beautiful

Vardges Sureniants

1899 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. Semiramis at the corpse of Ara the Beautiful. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The legendary encounter takes place low in a room that seems to exceed its actors. Semiramis bends toward Ara's body while decorated wall rises above them. That imbalance changes the scale of the event: the central figures are important to the story but occupy only a small part of the image. Architecture gives their isolation a visible measure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 39

05 / 25

Portrait of Mkrtich Khrimian

Vardges Sureniants

1906 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. Portrait of Mkrtich Khrimian. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A broad area of blue clothing steadies the portrait among plants, carpet and furniture. Khrimian's face and hands emerge from that large shape, while the room supplies a lived setting for his clerical identity. The chair gives his body a formal place, yet the surrounding objects prevent the sitter from becoming only an emblem of office.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 51

06 / 25

The Procession Leaving Etchmiadzin Cathedral

Vardges Sureniants

1895 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vardges Sureniants. The Departure of the Procession from St. Etchmiadzin Cathedral. Image credit: Vardges Sureniants. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Faces, banners and vestments collect beneath a portal much taller than the people passing through it. The entrance establishes scale; the crowd gives the building an active social use. Set beside the violated interiors, the difference is substantial. Similar architectural mass can enclose absence in one painting and frame a community's movement in another.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 71

07 / 25

Ani Cathedral

Arshak Fetvadjian

1905 · National Gallery of Armenia



Arshak Fetvadjian. Ani cathedral. Image credit: Arshak Fetvadjian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The roofline opens into the sky, making loss part of the cathedral's silhouette. Warm stone and repeated arches give the remaining structure enough definition to be read as a particular building. The sparse surroundings leave little competing activity. Fetvadjian lets both architectural description and the ruin's isolated position remain visible, without supplying figures to dramatise its condition.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 17744

08 / 25

Mount Ararat from Etchmiadzin

Yeghishe Tadevosyan

1895 · National Gallery of Armenia



Yeghishe Tadevosyan. Mounth Ararat from Ejmiadzin. Image credit: Yeghishe Tadevosian (1870 - 1936). Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A low strip of settlement gives way to the much larger blue mass of Ararat. Tadevosyan keeps the foreground economical, so the mountain's outline becomes the principal organising shape. Its dominance is made pictorially, through size and the scarcity of competing forms. The greenish sky gives the summit a distinct field against which to register.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 25

Aragats

Gevorg Bashinjaghian

1917 · National Gallery of Armenia



Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Aragats. Image credit: Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Cloud and light break the mountain into changing levels of visibility. Snowy peaks do not remain one continuous emblem; some slopes emerge while others withdraw into shade. Bashinjaghian's view gives weather an active role in describing the place. Compared with Tadevosyan's compact Ararat, it asks the eye to follow conditions across the breadth of a landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 110

10 / 25

Lake Sevan and Island in the Morning

Gevorg Bashinjaghian

1896 · National Gallery of Armenia



Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Lake Sevan and island in the morning. Image credit: Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dark shore establishes a near edge before the eye crosses the still water. A small boat helps measure the distance to the island, whose reflection softens its boundary. Almost everything depends on modest tonal changes. The lake feels extensive because its few elements are carefully separated, not because the painting supplies an abundance of detail.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 25

A Rainy Day at Sevan

Gevorg Bashinjaghian

1899 · National Gallery of Armenia



Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Rainy day in Sevan. Image credit: Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Rain and mist limit the distance that was so available in the morning view. The small sail and low island remain as points of orientation under a much heavier sky. Comparing the two Sevan pictures makes weather more than atmosphere: it changes the information the place offers and the space through which the eye can move.

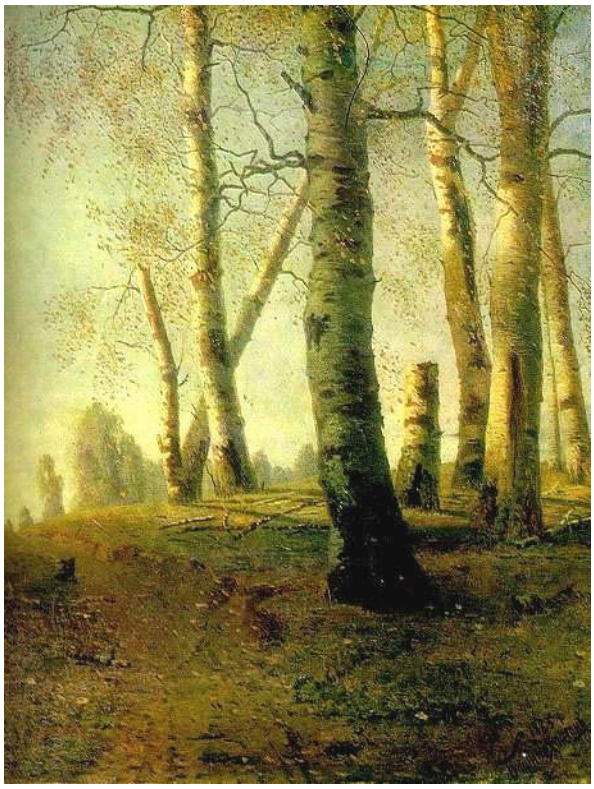
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4

12 / 25

Birch Grove

Gevorg Bashinjaghian

1883 · National Gallery of Armenia



Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Birch Grove. Image credit: Gevorg Bashinjaghian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Depth is assembled from repeated trunks rather than a distant landmark. The nearest birch stands apart from smaller trees behind, while dark bark marks interrupt the pale verticals. Sunlight produces further intervals among the leaves. Following those changes in size and spacing allows the grove to open gradually, one tree at a time.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 25

Mules Laden with Hay

Martiros Saryan

1910 · National Gallery of Armenia



Martiros Saryan. Mules, laden with hay. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The loads nearly conceal the animals carrying them. Small dark legs remain beneath large rounded bundles, making the imbalance between burden and bearer the picture's governing proportion. Saryan separates the bright forms clearly against yellow ground. Transport becomes a compact visual problem in weight, repetition and how little of an animal must remain visible for it to be recognised.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 25

Egyptian Masks

Martiros Saryan

1911 · National Gallery of Armenia



Martiros Saryan. Egyptian masks. Image credit: Martiros Saryan; Source credit: https://punto-di-vista.livejournal.com/51051.html. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Faces overlap in shallow space, with eyes and mouths repeated at different scales. The large yellow face anchors one side of the arrangement while colour separates neighbouring forms. The title gives a broad subject, but does not identify each object archaeologically. Saryan's painted relationships can be followed without supplying unsupported origins for every mask.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 207

15 / 25

Café Pittoresque

Georgy Yakulov

1917 · National Gallery of Armenia



Georgy Yakulov. Cafe Pittoresque. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Lettering occupies the same ochre field as the standing figure and small animal. It helps compose the sheet instead of waiting below as a caption. Yakulov therefore gives the café a visual identity without presenting a conventional interior view. Reading and looking become neighbouring activities, each requiring a share of the surface.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 25

Komitas

Yeghishe Tadevosyan

1936 · National Gallery of Armenia



Yeghishe Tadevosyan. Komitas. Image credit: Yeghishe Tadevosyan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

White clothing separates Komitas from the greens around him. His raised hand and turned head give direction to a tall standing figure, while smaller people continue the landscape behind. The portrait does not isolate its subject from the world. It keeps him identifiable within an environment that has room for other activities and distances.

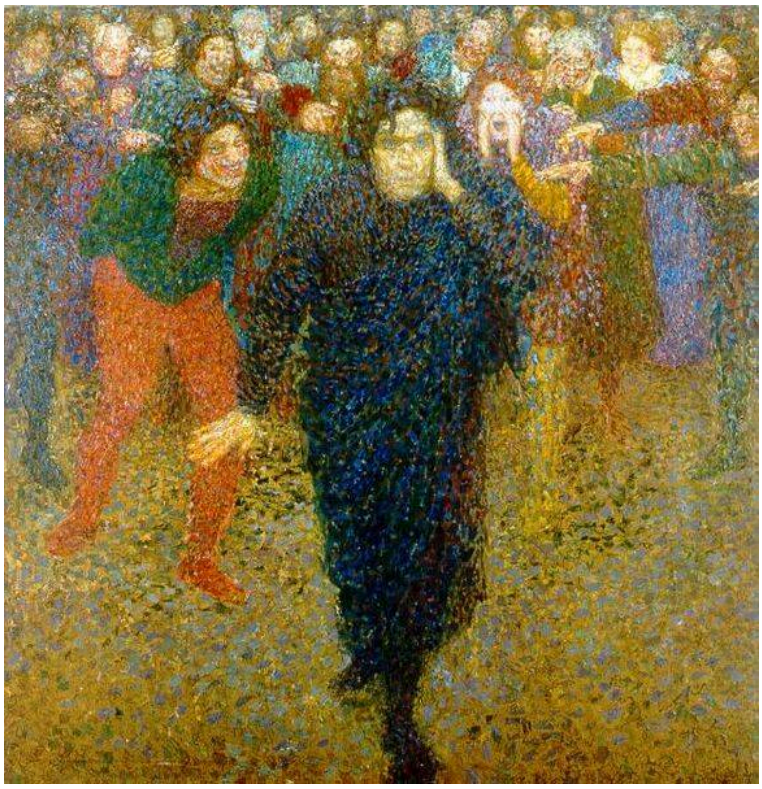
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2203

17 / 25

Talent and the Crowd

Yeghishe Tadevosyan

1909 · National Gallery of Armenia



Yeghishe Tadevosyan. Talent and the crowd. Image credit: Yeghishe Tadevosyan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title proposes a conflict; the interval between one advancing figure and the packed group makes it visible. Faces gather densely behind the darker body in front. That division is the safest starting point for interpretation. It allows the painting to address an individual's relation to collective pressure without requiring an invented historical incident to explain it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 127

18 / 25

The Courtyard of Sanahin Monastery

Panos Terlemezyan

1904 · National Gallery of Armenia



Panos Terlemezyan. Sanahin monastery courtyard. Image credit: Panos Terlemezyan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Separate patches of light reveal enough stone to suggest the surrounding vaults and columns. Much remains in shadow, so the space must be assembled across interruptions. Terlemezyan's inward view differs from the exposed silhouette at Ani. Here, enclosure is experienced through partial access to surfaces rather than through a complete architectural outline.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 164

19 / 25

A Shepherd from Lori

Panos Terlemezyan

1905 · National Gallery of Armenia



Panos Terlemezyan. Shepherd from Lori. Image credit: Panos Terlemezyan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Fur hat, belt and layered clothes identify the sitter through particular material things. His low hands leave the face and upper body carrying most of the encounter. The dark interior limits distraction without turning the shepherd into an anonymous type. Close description gives a working man's appearance the space usually granted to a formal portrait.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 177

20 / 25

Still Life with Vegetables

Hmayak Hakobyan

1901 · National Gallery of Armenia



Hmayak Hakobyan. Still Life. Vegetables. Image credit: Hmayak Hakobyan. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Each vegetable meets light differently. Rounded skin, cut surfaces and green stalks distinguish objects that overlap closely before a dark ground. Hakobyan makes their contact convincing through those differences: one rests against another, one edge interrupts the next. The still life offers a smaller-scale counterpart to the architectural pictures' attention to material surfaces.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 68

21 / 25

Still Life: Plums

Zakar Zakarian

1900 · National Gallery of Armenia



Zakar Zakarian. Still life. Plums. Image credit: Zakar Zakarian. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Only part of each object is sharply available. A glint describes a curve, then an edge disappears into the brown surroundings. Zakarian leaves the eye to join those fragments into fruit and vessels. The slower emergence of form contrasts with Hakobyan's more distinctly separated vegetables, despite the two paintings' closely related domestic subjects.

Object source · Open artwork

22 / 25

Seascape

Vartan Mahokian

1905 · National Gallery of Armenia



Vartan Mahokian. Seascape. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The horizon stays level while the nearer water breaks in competing directions. Pale foam separates the crests from the darker green beneath, making movement legible without a ship or coastal landmark. Mahokian distributes variation across a stable underlying view. The waves can differ because the distant boundary gives them something steady to move against.

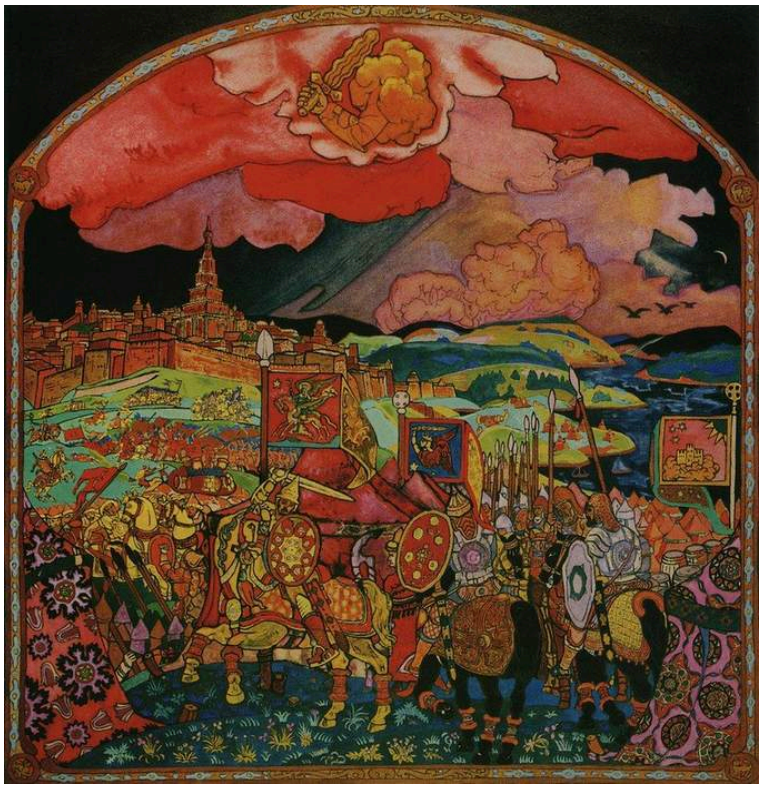
Object source · Open artwork

23 / 25

The Siege of Kazan

Nicholas Roerich

1914 · National Gallery of Armenia



Nicholas Roerich. Siege of Kazan. Image credit: Nicholas Roerich. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Roerich compresses people and fortifications into overlapping bands beneath large red and pink clouds. The sky takes on as much visual weight as the historical action below. Strong pattern gives the scene something of a theatrical arrangement. It offers an interpretation of the siege, rather than the kind of spatial account from which its movements could be reconstructed.

Object source · Open artwork

24 / 25

The Way of Giants

Nicholas Roerich

1914 · National Gallery of Armenia



Nicholas Roerich. Way of giants. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/nicholas-roerich/way-of-giants-1914 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The giants remain in the title. In the picture, interlocking blue rocks and a curling sky provide the legendary scale. Firm outlines keep the terrain unusually emphatic, while the forms above it flow. The contrast allows a landscape without visible protagonists to carry the expectation of a story through colour, solidity and proportion.

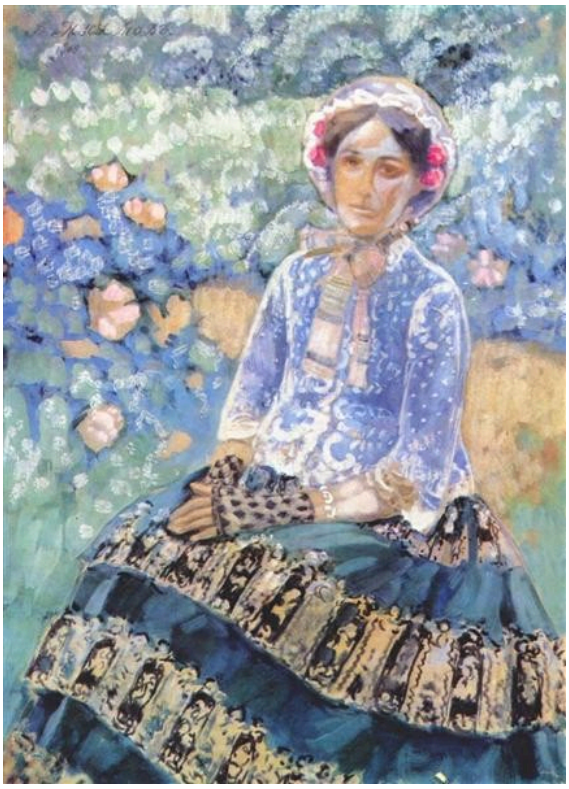
Object source · Open artwork

25 / 25

Woman in a Blue Dress

Victor Borisov-Musatov

1903 · National Gallery of Armenia



Victor Borisov-Musatov. Woman in Blue Dress. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Patterns on the dress continue the activity of surrounding leaves and flowers. The figure partly joins that decorative field, while face and hands remain clearer points of orientation. Borisov-Musatov allows person and setting to share a surface without making them identical. The spreading skirt gives the lower part of the composition its broadest connection between body and design.

Object source · Open artwork

Return to an empty interior

After the landscapes and portraits, the opening churches may seem less like backgrounds and more like subjects in their own right. Compare what survives, what has moved, and where people can still gather. The selection describes recorded works, not a permanent hanging; confirm access and current display with the gallery before visiting.

Further reading

Armenia: Art, Religion, and Trade in the Middle Ages

Helen C. Evans, editor; The Metropolitan Museum of Art · Read free · English PDF

An illustrated study of medieval Armenian art, available as a free PDF. Its coverage of churches and religious objects gives background to some of the places and subjects painted here. It is not a catalogue of the modern collection.

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by M. T. H. Sadler · Read free · English

Kandinsky's writing on colour and form, in an English translation. It offers a contemporary artist's arguments to consider beside the early twentieth-century paintings in this guide. It does not establish that their makers followed his ideas.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12